



## BEFORE

By the late 15th century, silver was in desperately short supply across Europe.

### EARLY SILVER

Silver is documented as being used as far back as the 3rd millennium BCE in the Middle East. It became the **most common coinage metal in Europe** from the 5th century BCE onward. Ironically, although the pre-Columbian civilizations of the Americas **210–13** had silver, it was cacao beans and spiny oyster shells that were used as payment. Silver was mainly used to make jewelry.

### PLUNDERING THE NEW WORLD

Imports from America included pearls, sugar, dyestuffs, and cowhide, but gold and silver were most highly prized. It was the **quest for gold and silver** that drove the Conquistadors and the early colonial ventures **230–31**. Gold and silver were plundered during the conquest. At first soldiers seized or bartered objects belonging to the native Americans. When these supplies were exhausted, gold was prospected by natives washing out surface gold from stream beds. Silver, however, required mining.

# Spanish Silver

**From the 1540s onward, the Spanish New World was shaped by the discovery, exploitation, and trading of silver around the world. The steady stream of silver into the Empire's coffers allowed Spain to become the superpower of its day, producing such imperial adventures as the Great Armada of 1588.**

**T**he discovery of silver at Potosí (present-day Bolivia) in April 1545 was not the first time the Spanish colonialists had encountered this precious metal. It was already being mined in the arid hills of New Spain (present-day Mexico), and in Peruvian mountain sites previously exploited by the Incas. In 1540, Spaniards began mining silver at Porco, located like Potosí to the southeast of Lake Titicaca. But five years later, the discovery of an entire mountain of silver ore (the biggest single concentration of this precious metal ever found) changed everything. Potosí quickly sprawled into a shanty village, growing in the next century to become the largest city in the New World with a population between 100,000 and 160,000. A royal

mint, established there in 1585, still stands today and, at some 13,600 ft (4,150 m) above sea level, Potosí remains the highest human habitation in the Americas.

Real exploitation of the Potosí mines took off around 1560 when a new and more productive method of refining silver came into use. The new process required mercury, for which the main source was the Almadén mines in Spain, but it yielded more silver than traditional smelting, and made it worthwhile to extract lower-grade, less concentrated seams of ore. The mercury was imported in leather



### Mestizo madonna

Catholic veneration of the Virgin Mary, adopted by Spanish American mestizo society (of mixed native American and European descent), produced this icon.

bags from Spain and became an important trade in itself. Silver mining also boosted the demand for supplies of beef, leather, and tallow candles. Mules were used to carry supplies to the

mines and bring back silver, so ranching and mining grew together.

Hard labor was soon in great demand, driving the import of African slaves (see pp.280–81). As both Mexico and Peru became wealthy from their mineral resources, the numbers of